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Employment Integration of Recent Immigrants in a Canadian Mid-Sized City: An Emerging Model

Mary Crea-Arsenio[1] | K. Bruce Newbold[2] | Andrea Baumann[1] | Margaret Walton-Roberts[3]

[1]Global Health, Faculty of Health Sciences, McMaster University, Hamilton, Ontario, Canada | [2]School of Earth, Environment & Society, McMaster University, Hamilton, Ontario, Canada | [3]Geography and Environmental Studies, Wilfrid Laurier University, Waterloo, Ontario, Canada

Correspondence: Mary Crea-Arsenio (mcrea@mcmaster.ca)

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ABSTRACT

With international migration on the rise and the critical need for labour in the global north, governments are increasingly focused on the employment integration of immigrants. Studies demonstrate that where immigrants choose to settle has an impact on how effectively they integrate into employment. In Canada, there has been a shift in immigrant settlement patterns away from large urban centres toward small and mid-sized cities. Understanding how local context shapes the employment integration of newcomers in their first few years of arrival is critical in informing policy to improve employment outcomes. Using a case study approach, this study explores the employment experiences of recent immigrants in a mid-sized city in Ontario, Canada to identify challenges and opportunities they face integrating into the local labour market. Findings were framed into an emerging model of immigrant employment-seeking strategies that identified how individual and contextual factors affect immigrant labour market integration. At the individual level, despite employing several strategies, most immigrants found themselves in low-skilled positions. At the city level, challenges were associated with a concentration of specific industries with a lower demand for diverse skill sets. Providing support at critical points of the integration process including prearrival and during the initial years postmigration can accelerate the uptake of immigrants into commensurate employment. This study contributes to further understanding of the important role of cities in ensuring the efficient and effective employment integration of immigrants into the Canadian labour market.

1 | Introduction

With international migration on the rise and the critical need for labour in the global north, countries are increasingly focused on the economic integration of immigrants. In Canada, immigration levels are at their highest since before the first world war. In 2023, 471,808 immigrants were admitted into the country and more than half of whom were under economic streams (Government of Canada 2024). By 2036, it is projected that immigrants will represent one-third of the population (Government of Canada 2023). Canada has long prioritized attracting highly skilled immigrants and ensuring the regional dispersion of immigrant settlement across the country. Among Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) countries, the country admits the highest number of skilled labour migrants (OECD 2019). Despite this, evidence suggests that recent immigrants perform poorly in the labour market when compared to their domestic-born counterparts (Crossman et al. 2021; Newman et al. 2018; Wong 2020; Yssaad and Fields 2018).

Studies have shown that immigrant settlement locations significantly influence their employment integration (Ali and Newbold 2020; Frank 2013; Laukova et al. 2022). Historically,

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most immigrants settled in one of Canada's three largest cities—Toronto, Montreal, or Vancouver (Statistics Canada 2022a; Bonikowska et al. 2017; Citizenship and Immigration Canada 2001; Walton-Roberts 2007, 2011). In the early 2000s, the government introduced regionalization policies to encourage immigration to smaller urban centres. Over time, these policies have contributed to a growing shift in settlement patterns toward small and mid-sized cities across the country (Bonikowska et al. 2017; Statistics Canada 2022a). However, this shift has presented unexpected challenges for smaller urban centres, particularly in providing adequate employment opportunities, settlement services and integration supports for newcomers (Crea-Arsenio et al. 2023).

Given the distinctive labour market dynamics in smaller urban centres, it is important to examine immigrant employment experiences in these settings to understand how to effectively support newcomers and maximize their contributions to local economies. Using a case study of the mid-sized city of Guelph, Ontario Canada, this study explores the path to employment by addressing the research question, how do recent immigrants integrate into employment in their first few years after arrival? By focusing on the place-based employment experiences of immigrants, the study aims to examine both individual and contextual factors affecting their integration into employment. Much of the research on immigrant employment focuses on the largest urban centres in Canada. There is a need to further understand how the local context shapes the employment decisions made by immigrants living in a mid-sized city and how these decisions have an impact on their employment pathway during their first few years after arrival.

The paper begins with an overview of the Canadian research on immigrant employment in small and mid-sized cities. Next, a summary of key theoretical considerations is presented followed by a brief description of the mid-sized city of Guelph. Following this, the main findings are presented in relation to individual immigrant experiences and the local context within which they pursued employment. Finally, conclusions are presented that provide new insight into the challenges facing immigrants as they integrate into the local economy with implications for policy improvements at all levels of government.

1.1 | Literature Review

Regionalized immigration in Canada aims to distribute the demographic, economic and social benefits of immigration more evenly across the country (Akbari and MacDonald 2014). One key strategy is the use of provincial nominee programmes (PNPs), which delegate certain federal immigration responsibilities to the provinces allowing them to select candidates based on regional labour market demands (Baglay and Nakache 2014). Another strategy is the development of Local Immigration Partnerships (LIPs), community-based initiatives aimed at enhancing the integration and settlement of immigrants locally.

Place-based initiatives, such as the PNPs and LIPs, are designed to attract immigrants by aligning immigration streams with regional labour market needs. In smaller urban centres, PNPs have been used to address skill shortages by selecting immigrants with in-demand qualifications. Although they have been successful in increasing immigrant settlement in these cities, research has shown that newcomers continue to encounter barriers to employment such as access to professional networks (Rice and Quan 2023). Similarly, research indicates that LIPs have been effective in fostering cross-sectoral partnerships and raising the profile of newcomer issues, particularly in smaller communities. However, challenges remain including securing consistent employer engagement and mainstream service participation.

Research in Canada has documented inconsistent findings related to immigrant employment outcomes in small and mid-sized cities. Some studies suggest that immigrants living in smaller urban centres earn higher incomes and have lower unemployment rates compared to those living in larger urban centres including Toronto, Montreal and Vancouver (Haan 2008; Hall and Khan 2008; Sano et al. 2017). Others suggest that immigrants face similar employment challenges in smaller urban centres as they do in larger centres (Guo 2013; Thomas 2021). For example, Guo (2013) found that Chinese recent immigrants in Calgary and Edmonton, Alberta, experienced de-skilling and devaluation of their education and work experience after immigrating to Canada. Additionally, Thomas (2021) interviewed immigrants in the two mid-sized cities of Edmonton, Alberta and Winnipeg, Manitoba, and found that immigrants experience significant labour market barriers and are often underemployed in their early years after settlement.

There is limited understanding of how the spatial context affects immigrant employment integration in Canada. This study explored newcomer experiences of finding employment in one mid-sized city. The focus was on recent immigrants, as they have been found to have the greatest labour market disadvantages (Crossman et al. 2021; Wong 2020). Despite being highly educated, they are less likely to be employed and when employed are often in low-skilled, precarious types of jobs. It is well-documented that the first few years after arrival are critical to the successful employment integration of newcomers (Crea-Arsenio et al. 2022). If a job match does not occur within this early timeframe wages and earnings remain low (Frank 2013). This study builds on an earlier study that identified how system influences impact immigrant employment in a mid-sized city (Crea-Arsenio et al. 2023). The findings demonstrated that few organizations play a large role in the immigrant employment pathway. Similarly, few industries dominate the labour market and drive employment locally. The challenge for immigrants is navigating the local system in those first few years after arrival to integrate into employment efficiently and effectively. Other studies suggest that place-based institutions such as LIPs and settlement services complement a city's ability to integrate immigrants into the local economy by improving access to services and social networks (Zhuang 2023).

The process of immigrant economic integration is not unidirectional. Studies have shown that immigrants play an active role in shaping their employment pathways. For example, immigrants choose various strategies to enter the labour market including engaging in 'gig' work, accessing social networks, and participating in ethnic economies (Lam and Triandafyllidou 2022; Rosales 2014;

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Roth et al. 2012). According to Jeon et al. (2019) the share of immigrants working in the gig economy is higher than the Canadian-born population. Although gig work can provide a point of entry into the labour market it has been shown to have negative effects on immigrant employment and income over time (Lamb et al. 2022). Yet there are cases where immigrants who are young and highly skilled use gig work as an opportunity to improve their socioeconomic situation (Lam and Triandafyllidou 2022). As Lam and Triandafyllidou note, these migrants 'are neither passive nor hopeless victims of exploitation... [as they seek] to use rather than be used by the [gig] economy' (Lam and Triandafyllidou 2022, 12).

Another documented strategy that immigrants use involves finding employment through social networks (Chuatico et al. 2022; Majerski 2019). According to Majerski (2019), most immigrants locate their first job through friends and close relatives. Although they may be successful in finding a job, it is often in a low-skilled position. Recent immigrants have not had enough time to establish ties that can lead to a variety of jobs with more occupational mobility (Majerski 2019). A related strategy is participating in an ethnic economy which involves migrant business owners hiring immigrants of the same ethnicity (Chuatico et al. 2022; Rosales 2014; Valenzuela-Garcia et al. 2017). Ethnic economies are more likely to form in large metropolitan areas and have been reported to be beneficial for new immigrants and refugees in the first few years after arrival. However, these are often individuals with low levels of education and language proficiency (Chuatico et al. 2022).

As the literature suggests, recent immigrants face the greatest economic disadvantages including underemployment, low earnings and high participation in precarious employment (Hira-Friesen 2018a, 2018b; Lewchuk 2017). The trend persists despite increased government attention and a growing need for labour. Much of the literature on immigrant employment focuses on human capital theory to explain integration challenges of newcomers. These studies emphasize issues of foreign credential recognition and language proficiency as the barriers to the transfer of immigrant human capital. More recently, authors have shifted the focus away from immigrant characteristics to examine how social capital plays a role in employment integration process. Social capital is the accumulation of resources embedded in networks that are created through personal relationships and maintained through mutual exchange (Chuatico et al. 2022). These social investments are instrumental in helping migrants integrate into employment and the broader society (Majerski 2019; Nakhaie and Kazemipur 2013). Few studies have examined the impact of the local context in shaping immigrant access to social capital in the labour market.

1.2 | Setting the Context

The city of Guelph, with a population of 165,588, is a census metropolitan area (CMA) located in the southwestern region of the province of Ontario. CMAs are cities with a population of more than 100,000 and a central core that is geographically, socially and economically integrated with adjacent areas (Statistics Canada 2018). In Canada, there are a total of 41 CMAs (Statistics Canada 2022a). Urban centres can be further classified based on the number of residents (Bernard 2008). Based on this classification, Guelph is categorized as a mid-sized urban centre and is surrounded by other large urban centres including Toronto.

Guelph is one of the fastest growing cities in Ontario largely driven by immigration. In 2021, 22.7% of the total population were immigrants and 16.9% (6005) were recent immigrants who arrived between 2016 and 2021. This percentage is higher than both the provincial (13.9%) and national (15.9%) level of recent immigrants (Statistics Canada 2022b). In 2021, the top places of birth for all immigrants were India, the United Kingdom, the Philippines and Vietnam. Among recent immigrants, the top places of birth were India, Eritrea, the Philippines and Syria (Statistics Canada 2022b).

Guelph is also a leading city in terms of job growth and low unemployment. It has a diverse economic landscape primarily centred on manufacturing, agriculture and knowledge-based industries (City of Guelph 2022). The city also has a growing service sector and a rising demand for technology-related skills. For immigrants, employment prospects are concentrated in both skilled and semiskilled manufacturing roles, with some also entering service-based roles in healthcare, retail and hospitality. Its proximity to larger urban centres has a significant influence on the employment structure for newcomers. For example, newcomers with unique qualifications may be more willing to settle in Guelph if they have access to regional job opportunities within commuting distance. In terms of support services, Guelph has several newcomer-focused resources, such as Immigrant Services Guelph-Wellington, which provides employment assistance, language training and settlement support (Crea-Arsenio et al. 2023). Earlier studies of the city demonstrated that services are limited and could benefit from further expansion and specialization to address the unique needs of specific immigrant populations (Crea-Arsenio et al. 2023).

The city of Guelph was chosen as a case study because it exemplifies the key characteristics that research has shown to be attractive to immigrants. The presence of a large immigrant population, a high-performing labour market, and its size and location relative to other large urban centres, make it an ideal case to study the employment integration of newly arrived immigrants (Esses et al. 2010; Haan 2008; Hyndman et al. 2006).

2 | Research Methods

Grounded theory methods were used to interview immigrants and refugees who arrived in Canada within the last 10 years and were either employed or seeking employment. A convenience sample of 20 immigrants were purposefully selected through immigrant-serving agencies including local immigrant services and employment agencies. Purposeful sampling involves selecting individuals that are experienced with the phenomenon of interest (Creswell 2007). The inclusion criteria were individuals residing in the city of Guelph who immigrated to Canada within the last 10 years, were between 25 and 54, spoke conversational English and were either employed or actively seeking employment. Interviews took place between August and October 2020.

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A semistructured interview guide was developed based on key themes identified from the immigrant employment integration literature. Immigrants were asked about their experiences of finding employment upon arrival including the strategies they used and challenges they faced. For those who were employed, questions focused on the relationship between their premigration education and their current employment position. Interviews lasted between 40 and 60 min, were conducted via zoom and were transcribed verbatim. A constant comparative method of analysis was used to compare immigrants based on gender, age, immigrant category and employment status (employed/unemployed) (Fram 2013). Employment integration was defined as the process of entering the workforce efficiently, effectively and with productive employment (Crea-Arsenio et al. 2023). Commensurate employment was measured as a perceived job match between premigration occupation and postmigration employment.

Preliminary coding was carried out by two members of the research team who coded several texts independently. Team members then collaborated to develop a refined scheme for coding the texts. Data from the initial interviews were coded using line-by-line analysis to first name categories relevant to the research question. As new categories emerged from the data, axial coding replaced open coding (Strauss and Corbin 1990). Throughout this phase, relationships between salient categories were connected and integrated. The last phase of analysis involved selective coding and included abstraction and organization of the main categories to form a conceptual framework of immigrant perceptions of employment in Canada (Strauss and Corbin 1990; Fram 2013).

To assess the trustworthiness of the data, the interviewer conducted periodic checks with the participants during each interview to verify interpretations of what was being said and to ensure their meanings were not misunderstood. Additionally, peer debriefing was used to explore meanings, clarify interpretations and test working hypotheses as they emerged (Nowell et al. 2017). Memo writing was used to track emerging themes and ideas throughout the data collection and analysis process. Immediately following each interview, ideas that arose throughout the interview process were documented in a reflexive journal to identify any personal biases and/or assumptions.

3 | Results

Table 1 displays the characteristics of the immigrants interviewed. A total of 20 individuals participated in the study, 10 males and 10 females. At the time of the interview, most participants were between 30 and 39 years of age and had been living in Canada for 3–5 years. Eleven of the 20 participants arrived in Canada as refugees, 4 immigrated under the family class, 3 had come as international students, and 2 arrived as economic applicants. All except one reported postsecondary education as their highest level of education.

At the time of the interviews, 15 participants were employed and 5 were seeking employment. Of those employed, 6 perceived their current job as closely matched to their education and training (see Table 1).

An emerging model of immigrant employment-seeking strategies was derived from interviews with recent immigrants residing in the city of Guelph (see Figure 1).

As the model displays, broader contextual factors impact on immigrant employment integration including federal immigration policy, the local economy, the municipal immigration strategy and the city's economic development plan. These factors have both direct and indirect influence on the newcomers as they navigate the pathway to employment. Canada's immigration selection policy favours newcomers who are highly skilled and highly educated with the assumption that they are more likely to succeed in the labour market. However, in this study, only two participants had immigrated under the economic class while more than half had arrived as refugees. Under the refugee status, participants are given 1 year of financial support as they resettle into their host community, yet many noted that they were struggling to find commensurate employment within the timeframe. The local economy presented unique challenges for many of the participants. In the city of Guelph, few industries dominated the labour market included manufacturing where most available jobs were identified. For many newcomers, the jobs were not aligned with their skills and qualifications and often resulted in many being underemployed or unemployed. The city's economic development strategy included a targeted approach to advancing existing industry clusters focused on manufacturing, agri-innovation and clean technology. While the strategy emphasized the city's potential growth in these industries, the incorporation of immigration and newcomer worker needs was absent in the development plan. Finally, the municipal immigration strategy actualized through the Guelph-Wellington LIP provided a basis for local initiatives to attract, recruit and retain newcomers to the city. Although the LIP does not provide direct services to immigrants, their role involves the coordination of key stakeholders including representatives from the private sector, all three levels of government and civil society organizations. Embedded within this broader structure are newcomers who are actively seeking employment. At the individual level, findings revealed that the pathway to commensurate employment for new immigrants involved three stages: settling and searching, trying and testing and adapting and accepting. At each stage immigrants use different strategies with varying degrees of success.

3.1 | Settling and Searching: The Importance of Finding Rapid Employment

Stage 1 involved the immediate time after arrival when immigrants reported settling in their new community and beginning an initial job search. The urgency of finding a job was evident. Interviewees described the importance of finding employment soon after arrival for survival and to feel integrated into Canadian life. One refugee stated, 'the first thing I will need to start my life is a job' (B1). Immigrants indicated that there was a sense of urgency to find employment for 'financial and psychological reasons' (B11). As an immigrant from India noted, 'we could not survive with the money that we brought along from India to Canada. So, survival starts with money and money comes with a job. There's no other way to start' (B19).

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TABLE 1 | Demographic characteristics of immigrant sample.

ID	Age	Sex	Years in Canada	Country of origin	Immigration class	Highest level of education	Currently employed	Occupation/job	Employ-ment status	Perceived job match
1	50–59	M	5	Syria	Privately sponsored refugee	High School	Yes	Factory worker	Full-time	Yes
2	20–29	F	5	Syria	Privately sponsored refugee	College, Business Administration	Yes	Human resource specialist	Part-time	Yes
3	30–39	F	1	Philippines	Family class	University Bachelor	No	N/A		
4	50–59	M	5	Eritrea	Refugee claimant	College, Marine Engineering Diploma	Yes	Machine operator – Manufacturing	Full-time	No
5	30–39	M	4	Palestine	Refugee claimant	University Bachelor	Yes	Employment counsellor	Part-time	Yes
6	30–39	F	4	Palestine	Refugee claimant	University Bachelor	No	N/A		
7	20–29	M	3	India	Student visa	Master's Mechanical Engineering	Yes	Manufacturing technician	Full-Time	No
8	30–39	F	2	Syria	Privately sponsored refugee	College	Yes	Restaurant worker	Part-time	No
9	40–49	M	1	Iran	Student visa	Doctorate Computer Science	Yes	University researcher	Full-time	Yes
10	30–39	F	5	Syria	Privately sponsored refugee	University Bachelor's Teaching	Yes	Hairstylist	Part-time	No
11	40–49	M	3	Nigeria	Family class	University Bachelor's, unspecified	Yes	Operations and administrative Support	Full-time	No
12	30–39	M	5	Kuwait	Privately sponsored refugee	University Bachelor's unspecified	Yes	Uber driver	Part-time	No
13	30–39	F	5	Syria	Privately sponsored refugee	University Bachelor's Chemistry	No	N/A		
14	40–49	F	2	China	Family class	Master's Law	No	N/A		
15	40–49	M	5	Syria	Privately sponsored refugee	Master's Geology	Yes	Factory worker	Full-time	No

(Continues)

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TABLE 1 | (Continued)

ID	Age	Sex	Years in Canada	Country of origin	Immigration class	Highest level of education	Currently employed	Occupation/job	Employment status	Perceived job match
16	30–39	F	4	Afghanistan	Refugee claimant	University Bachelor's Accounting	Yes	Nursing home dietary aide	Part-time	No
17	30–39	M	6	Eritrea	Student visa	University Bachelor's unspecified	No	N/A		
18	30–39	F	7	Brazil	Student visa	Master's Linguistics	Yes	Social services worker	Full-time, contract	No
19	30–39	F	6	India	Economic applicant	University Bachelor's Science	Yes	Bank teller	Full-time	Yes
20	30–39	M	6	India	Economic applicant	University Bachelor's Computer Science	Yes	Information technology	Full-time	Yes

Others described that employment allowed them to feel rapidly integrated into a community. For example, one immigrant reported, '... immigrants want to get involved in society to feel a sense of belonging to a community. I'd wanted to get involved and find employment to gain my local experience, and to know more about the culture' (B14). Another stated, 'I think employment is the only thing which makes you feel integrated into the city actually' (B20).

Many immigrants engaged in common practices such as using popular job sites, asking family and friends and accessing local agencies to seek out opportunities. Although participants described applying to 'hundreds of jobs' (B16) using various strategies, few had success finding employment in this initial stage. They identified challenges associated with applying for jobs online. One highly skilled immigrant reflected, 'on the job websites, when they post for one job, they could get a thousand applications. So, I think if you have a connection to that company, it could help' (B11). As a result, several immigrant interviewees described using family, friends and sponsors to connect to the local employment context.

Family and friends were key in assisting immigrants with accessing services and knowing where to go and what to do when searching for employment. As one immigrant reported, 'my brother-in-law helps me a lot to access these services. When I arrived at the airport, they gave me a box to inform me that there are services but my brother-in-law, he is the one who drove me to immigration services and told me about what I need to do' (B8). In the case of privately sponsored refugees, the sponsor was instrumental in helping find that first Canadian job. A refugee reported, 'my sponsor got me connected with the CEO of a company and then I worked with this company for almost two years. It was a digital marketing company. But after the two years, the company was losing a lot of money, so they let people go and I was one of them' (B12). Although participants had been successful in attaining employment through connections made by family, friends and sponsors, many described that the type of job was not ideal. When a petroleum engineer realised the time and money it would take to have his credentials recognized in Canada, a friend referred him to '... work a delivery job for Amazon' (B3).

Another strategy used by immigrants was accessing local settlement and employment services to aid in their search efforts. This approach was primarily successful for lower-skilled applicants who could quickly transition into manufacturing positions. For highly skilled applicants, there were mixed results. An immigrant reported, 'how I work with settlement services is when I see a job out there, I prepare my resume and cover letter and then I send it to my employment counsellor to review. She goes through it and adds anything needed and then I apply for the job. So, they know where I applied and if they have a connection to that employer, they can follow up for me' (B17). Although some of the immigrants interviewed had success matching to employment through connections made by local settlement and employment services, others indicated that they were unsuccessful or placed in low-skilled jobs. As one immigrant described, 'for the higher educated people [services] are useless because they are going to find you work in manufacturing, which is easy to find without them' (B15). For a few

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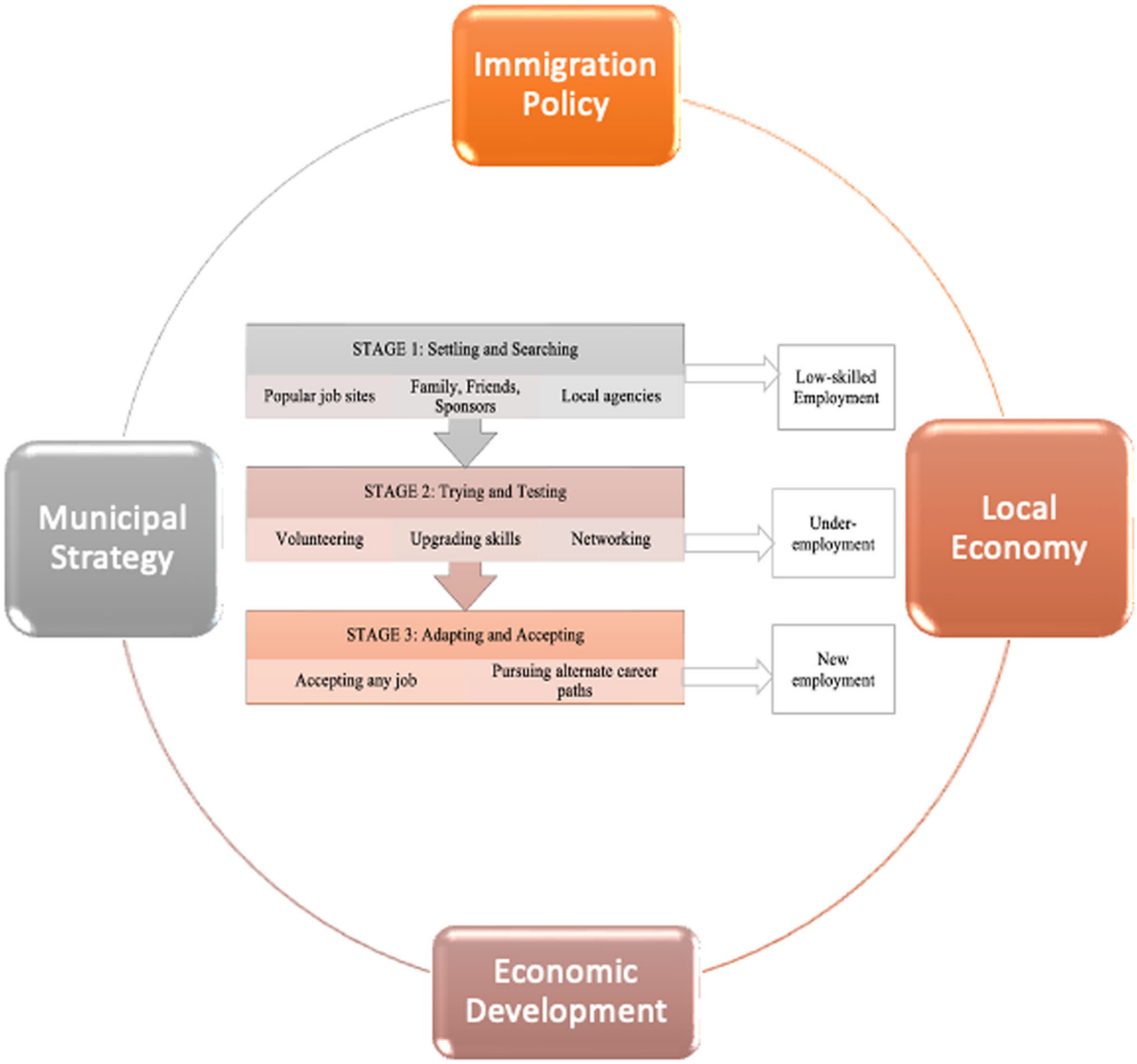

FIGURE 1 | Recent immigrants employment-seeking strategies.

immigrants, these initial strategies successfully resulted in finding a job, although most often in a low-skilled position. For others, finding a job required more effort and many engaged in trying and testing different approaches to improving their chances of finding employment.

3.2 | Trying and Testing: Improving Employability

In stage 2, immigrant participants recognized that to be competitive in the local labour market, they needed to gain Canadian experience. Consequently, they engaged in various strategies including volunteering, upgrading skills and networking in the local community. More than half identified volunteering as a strategy to improve their prospects for employment. Volunteering served multiple purposes for immigrants. It provided an opportunity to gain exposure to Canadian workplaces. As one immigrant described, 'I volunteered to be a part of a youth group that goes to local schools and talks to new immigrant students. I've worked with youths in the past, so I opted for that position' (B12). It also helped some immigrants improve their English skills. An immigrant reported, 'after a couple of months, I started going to volunteer at church sales to connect with people and make myself comfortable talking and listening to what they say, so I learn more English' (B2). Others used volunteering to build their professional networks. An immigrant described how he grew his network 'by doing some volunteering in the community and through that got connected to human resources of multiple companies and many people' (B15).

Some of the immigrants interviewed described taking courses to upgrade their skills or attain certifications for different jobs. Many reported taking as many courses as they could to improve their chances of employment. As one immigrant indicated, 'I did ESL courses, I did receptionist training from Action Read, I did school bus training, I did the food handling certificate and I have the Ontario safety certificate. Right now, I am doing the

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office course for PowerPoint, Excel and Word' (B16). These employment-seeking activities should have provided them with opportunities to gain meaningful employment. However, many had limited success in finding commensurate work and were forced to find and accept any job.

A final strategy used by several immigrant interviewees was to enlarge their social network in the context of employment. One immigrant reported how a casual conversation with a stranger resulted in an employment opportunity. He described, '... I was having a chat with someone I didn't know about career goals and job opportunities, and I told him that I noticed there was a job posted at the company where he was working. He told me to send him my resume and he would refer me. I did that and then they called me' (B17). In another instance, an immigrant described being at a social event and approaching one of the workers to ask how they found their job. He stated, 'I just asked 'how did you get this job?' So, he explained how he got the job, and I just followed the same ways and got that job too' (B19).

3.3 | Adapting and Accepting: Local Realities

Stage 3 involved immigrants adapting and accepting their new employment realities. The strategies they used in this stage involved taking any job to enter the labour market and pursuing alternate career paths. Immigrants described a process of lowering their expectations of employment as a way to survive. Many talked about taking a job far below their skills and qualifications including 'gig' work such as driving an Uber and working in low-skilled jobs to make a full-time wage. As one immigrant reported, 'another thing I did because I had to survive, was work as a security guard. But I had to downgrade my resume. I didn't show that I had a Bachelor's in Computer Science with six years of experience or that I was a Team Leader with JP Morgan in India. I just showed my interest in the security job' (B19). Some immigrants used survival jobs to offset the negative effects of being unemployed. An immigrant described, 'I was completely jobless, and I was restless because I was idle, so I took a job at the University. It was basically working with the hospitality team. Working in the kitchen, doing dishes, going to the wholesale to pack things. It was very unskilful, but it was just to get some job experience' (B11). Despite being educated and highly skilled, several immigrants indicated that getting any job was a strategy they used to avoid being told they lacked Canadian work experience.

Another barrier identified by interviewees was related to foreign credential recognition. Despite holding a professional degree, immigrants encountered many obstacles to having their credentials recognized in Canada. In response, many chose to pursue alternative career paths. In some cases, this involved applying to a position within the same occupation but at a lower status. A lawyer from China described why they decided to become a paralegal instead of pursuing law, 'first, it is time-consuming. Even if it goes very smoothly, it will probably take me at least two years to go through the process. And second, there is an issue of cost. Preparing for the exams and writing the exam takes money. Also, if I attend law school, would require money. And then the third issue is that I have a little daughter. So, it would be difficult for me to balance the process and taking care of my daughter' (B14).

In other cases, immigrants decided to pursue an occupation outside their profession. A teacher from Turkey described how she decided to become a hairstylist because the programme was 'only one year and after that, [she could] begin work right away' (B10). Several highly skilled immigrants talked about taking courses at local private colleges that promised quick entry into the labour market. However, the jobs they found were still low-paying and often in a part-time capacity. One immigrant who held a master's degree in Geology reported taking a 1-year programme in information technology and immediately finding a part-time minimum wage job that he described as 'not enough for somebody to provide for their family' (B15).

Despite finding a job, immigrant interviewees reported how difficult it was for them to accept their new position in society. Almost all interviewees had established careers before immigrating to Canada and many expected that they would attain commensurate employment within their first few years after arrival. When this did not happen, they were forced to 'manage their emotions' while renegotiating the meaning of employment under these new conditions. An engineer from Eritrea reported '...there is no green grass over here where you can come and then get what you want, there is always a challenge everywhere you go if you are new, whether skilled or not skilled. When I was back home, I was one of the best, but now no one can give me a chance. So, you must control your emotions because there is frustration sometimes' (B17). Another highly skilled immigrant noted, 'if you are telling someone who was an engineer for almost 15 years, you're going to start from scratch, you're going to lose them' (B12). As many of the participants reported, finding commensurate employment soon after arrival was imperative to their successful integration into the local community. Without the opportunity for meaningful employment, many immigrants would choose to leave the city.

3.4 | Immigrant Perspectives on Commensurate Employment

The following section outlines immigrant perspectives on their experiences of finding commensurate employment and how to improve employment outcomes for newcomers. Of the participants who did attain commensurate employment, many described the importance of building social capital as a key feature of their success. They believed that networking with community members in diverse settings led to opportunities to pursue avenues for employment that were not openly advertised. By contrast, participants who had not attained commensurate employment described limited opportunities to network informally with local community members. Those who were admitted under the family class and as international students identified a lack of social capital and limited knowledge of the local economy as key barriers to employment. Those admitted under refugee status described the challenge of being 'stuck' in their initial employment which was low-skilled and precarious.

Overall, there was consensus among the interviewees that Canada's current points-based system is a valid approach to immigrant selection. But several identified frustrations with the lack of follow through. An immigrant reported, 'we all get screened for our application as an immigrant. If there are two of us, we both

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apply and I get higher points in my entry, it's meaningless when we arrive. When you come here, we're assessed the same, back to zero' (B3). Immigrants believed that the government should have a 'plan' to better integrate newcomers into employment once they arrive. As one immigrant noted, this plan could involve 'an immigrant service worker and government agent sitting down with new immigrants as they arrive and asking them, what is your target? What kind of work do you want? Do you want to be a welder? OK. We're going to work with that. You must improve your English to this level, so you must go to this course. We will work with you until you get the certificate and then you can work in the career you wanted' (B15). It was evident that highly skilled immigrants were interested in a guided understanding of the employment pathway and an efficient plan to achieve positive results in the Canadian labour market.

Another area identified was the need for better evaluation and monitoring of highly skilled workers early in the process. An immigrant described, 'it would be very beneficial for immigrants to have someone who evaluates them based on their experiences, rather than on documents. It's hard for anyone to get a job without having experience here. So why not make things easier for them, putting them in a place, observing them, and then giving them the feedback, whether they are suitable or not?' (B6). Another immigrant noted that the government '... needs a monitoring system, to keep monitoring people, especially the high degree people. They need to be prepared for when 90 percent of them do not have a job right away. Then they would need a process of how to help them if they don't have a job' (B11).

A final area identified by immigrant participants was to improve prearrival services to include more detailed information about different sectors of employment. Prearrival services are free programmes for people who have been approved to immigrate to Canada (Government of Canada 2022). They provide assessment and a personalized plan to help individuals settle once they arrive. Some services are targeted toward professions such as engineering and nursing while others are more general. One immigrant with a background in banking explained that she would have benefitted from knowing about the financial sector before she arrived in Canada. She reported, 'I was working with a bank in India before I immigrated. I was not aware of how many banks there were in Canada or what the banking structure was like here. So, if they set up a few people in pre-arrival who could train us on this and say, "OK, you are going to Canada. Canada has these top five banks, this, this, this, this. And if you want to work there as a Teller, or as a Branch Manager, you need to get these kinds of certifications. Of course, your experience will help you, but still, you need these certifications, like the Canadian Securities course"' (B20). As this quote demonstrates, prearrival services are important for skilled immigrants and an area that could be enhanced to improve immigrant knowledge about employment in Canada.

4 | Discussion

This study explored the employment experiences of recent immigrants in the mid-sized city of Guelph, Ontario Canada. It presents an interesting case to examine immigrant employment as the city is known for its low unemployment rate and steady job growth. Within this context it was assumed that immigrants would efficiently and effectively integrate into employment. The study findings led to an emerging model of immigrant employment-seeking strategies wherein both individual (immigrant strategies and decisions) and contextual factors (local employment context) affected how immigrants enter the labour market. The model serves as a valuable tool for advancing our understanding of the employment trajectories of new immigrants in small and mid-sized cities and provides essential insights for policymakers in designing targeted interventions aimed at improving employment outcomes.

The model underscores the importance of understanding the larger structural factors that affect immigrant employment as well as the available service infrastructure that supports integration into the local community. While underemployment among immigrants remains a pervasive issue, this study suggests that it may be exacerbated in smaller urban centres. The limited number of service providers creates a vulnerability for newcomers, particularly when these providers experience disruptions. Furthermore, the restricted pool of employers in smaller centres constrains employment opportunities, reducing the range of employment choices available. Findings also draw attention to the prevalence of precarious work which erodes expectations as newcomers attempt to find commensurate employment.

The municipal immigration strategy and local economy play a crucial role in shaping an immigrant's job search and employment outcomes. Findings from this study suggest that immigrants navigate a sequence of settling and searching for jobs, experimenting with different opportunities and ultimately adapting by accepting any available employment to enter the labour market. While they actively make decisions throughout this process, their choices are constrained by the local employment context and shaped by key actors in the immigrant employment space.

For example, in small and mid-sized cities, immigrant-serving organizations that offer employment support are limited, and many have pre-existing relationships with local employers (Senthanar et al. 2020; Lumley-Sapanski 2019). As a result, employer networks become the primary gateway to job opportunities for newcomers. However, these jobs often do not align with immigrants' skills, qualifications, or intended career paths. Instead, they are encouraged to accept any available position as an entry point into the labour market. Many who rely on local employment services find themselves placed in low-skilled roles, frequently in factory settings, despite possessing advanced qualifications.

Beyond the availability of employment services, the overall economic landscape of a city also influences how quickly immigrants secure meaningful work. In cities where industries are concentrated in trades, services, or manufacturing, highly skilled immigrants often struggle to find jobs that match their expertise. The limited demand for diverse skill sets forces many to choose between taking any available job or pursuing an alternative career path.

As they navigate these challenges, immigrants often turn to friends and family as a primary source of job information.

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While social networks can provide critical support, they can also inadvertently limit employment prospects. Studies suggest that strong social ties help immigrants integrate into the local community and improve well-being (Majerski 2019; Walton-Roberts 2005). However, over-reliance on these networks can also restrict opportunities for acquiring official language skills and advancing in the workforce. Developing programmes that facilitate interactions between immigrants and broader community members could help expand their social capital, opening pathways to better employment opportunities.

Implications for policy are based on converging evidence suggesting that although many immigrants can find employment in their first few years in Canada, the jobs often do not align with their premigration education and training. Given that the strategies used by immigrants are not enough to facilitate successful employment integration, policies that focus on enhancing support before arrival and in the first few years after arrival are needed.

At the national level, there is a need for further investment and enhancement of existing prearrival services. In Canada, the federal government made substantial investment into prearrival services for newcomers to facilitate their integration upon arrival (Government of Canada 2022). Existing services include employment services, family and youth services, settlement information and general information about living in Canada. The challenge for many newcomers is that the employment information is often general and not specific to the local context. More detailed information about industries in-demand and the geographic regions where jobs are available would provide immigrants with a more comprehensive understanding of the realities of navigating the Canadian labour market.

At the provincial level, there is a need to re-evaluate the allocation of immigrant selection to the PNPs. Provincial governments have unique labour market challenges based on dominant regional industries that require targeted skills and occupations. Providing provincial governments with a greater share of immigrant selection will not only improve the regional dispersion of newcomers, but also help to relieve labour shortages across the country. Provinces also have an important role to play to ensure cities and employers are involved in setting criteria for selection. To benefit newly arriving, highly skilled immigrants, any points allocated to in-demand occupations should be aligned with existing employment opportunities. This would require governments to work more closely with employers at a local level to identify open positions that could be shared with immigrants who score high on relevant occupations.

At the local level, immigrant services should adapt programmes to meet the diverse needs of newcomers by capitalizing on the skills and experience they bring to the community. Providing industry specific information to guide employment decisions and expanding collaborations with employers, governments and other nongovernmental organizations is needed to leverage the expertise and networks that can improve immigrant employment integration. Furthermore, municipalities should develop their own strategic plan to integrate newcomers that reflects the unique attributes of the city's employment context. With limited funding and services in most small and mid-sized cities, there are opportunities to foster better communication and collaboration across centres. Improved coordination can enhance data and lessons learned, with the goal of identifying synergistic opportunities.

While this study revealed new insights into the local employment experiences of recent immigrants to Canada, there were some notable limitations. The sample was small and primarily obtained through local immigrant services. Although there may be important differences in employment outcomes between those who access services versus those that do not, the findings do offer some preliminary data about how to improve services to support employment pathways for recent immigrants to Canada. Furthermore, most interviewees were admitted to Canada under refugee status which may have resulted in additional barriers to employment integration. Refugees were able to find employment rapidly, but like other immigrant interviewees, the type of jobs were low-skilled, temporary and with limited opportunities for advancement. As the model shows, the barriers to attaining commensurate employment are complex and interconnected with broader systemic factors at the national, regional and local level. Although the sample was weighted toward the refugee group, the findings are supported by other studies that suggest recent immigrants encounter similar challenges entering the labour market in small and mid-sized cities. To further support the model, future research should target a larger sample of immigrants across multiple cities to identify challenges and opportunities to improve the employment integration process for newcomers. Finally, the interviews were conducted during the first wave of the COVID-19 pandemic. At the time of the interviews, most services were provided online and many businesses had shuttered. Despite these additional challenges, the interviewees were able to access services and did continue their job searches. With the resumption of full services, future research into the employment experiences of newcomers in the city would be valuable to ascertain whether the identified issues persist.

5 | Conclusion

This study provides insight into the process of immigrant employment integration in a mid-sized city by introducing a model of employment-seeking strategies that includes both individual and contextual factors. Findings demonstrate a need for continuous monitoring of immigrant employment outcomes at a local level to assure effective and efficient integration into the labour market. Providing support at critical points of the integration process including prearrival and during the initial years postmigration can accelerate the uptake of immigrants into meaningful employment. Mid-sized cities across Canada will continue to face labour shortages that require enhanced immigration. Focusing on local initiatives to improve employment integration of immigrants can help cities advocate for more effective policy and programming across all levels of government.

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Ethics Statement

Ethics approval was received from the McMaster Research Ethics Board (MREB#: 5302).

Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

Data Availability Statement

The data that support the findings of this study are available from the corresponding author, upon reasonable request.

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